gas into the circulation. This increase in blood nitrogen content can lead to a condition called **nitrogen narcosis.** When the diver ascends to the surface too quickly a condition called **'bends' or decompression sickness** occurs and nitrogen comes out of solution while still in the blood forming bubbles. Small bubbles in the blood are not harmful, but large bubbles can lodge in small capillaries, blocking blood flow or can press on nerve endings. Decompression sickness is associated with pain in joints and muscles and neurological problems including stroke. The risk of nitrogen narcosis and bends is common in **scuba divers**.

During carbon–dioxide poisoning, the demand for oxygen increases. As the $O_2$ level in the blood decreases it leads to suffocation and the skin turns bluish black.




**Allergy** is caused by allergens. When we enter a polluted area, immediately we start sneezing and coughing. The allergens in that place affect our respiratory tracts and the responses to the allergens start within minutes. Allergens provoke an inflammatory response. A common manifestation of allergy is Asthma.

## 6.8 Disorders of the Respiratory system

Respiratory system is highly affected by environmental, occupational, personal and social factors. These factors may be responsible for a number of respiratory disorders. Some of the disorders are discussed here.

### Asthma

It is characterized by narrowing and inflammation of bronchi and bronchioles and difficulty in breathing. Common allergens for asthma are dust, drugs, pollen grains, certain food items like fish, prawn and certain fruits etc.

### Emphysema

Emphysema is chronic breathlessness caused by gradual breakdown of the thin walls of the alveoli decreasing the total surface area of a gaseous exchange. i.e., widening of the alveoli is called emphysema. The major cause for this disease is cigarette smoking, which reduces the respiratory surface of the alveolar walls.

### Bronchitis

The bronchi when it gets inflated due to pollution smoke and cigarette smoking, causes bronchitis. The symptoms are cough, shortness of breath and sputum in the lungs.

### Pneumonia

Inflammation of the lungs due to infection caused by bacteria or virus is called pneumonia. The common symptoms are sputum production, nasal congestion, shortness of breath, sore throat etc.

### Tuberculosis

Tuberculosis is caused by *Mycobacterium tuberculae*. This infection mainly occurs in the lungs and bones. Collection of fluid between the lungs and the chest wall is the main complication of this disease.

### Occupational respiratory disorders

The disorders due to one's occupation of working in industries like grinding or stone breaking, construction sites, cotton industries, etc. Dust produced affects the respiratory tracts. Long exposure can give rise to inflammation leading to fibrosis.



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